

Using these terms, we can state the Principle of Sufficient Reason as follows:

The basic idea behind the principle is this: Take any feature of the world. If the world could have failed to be that way, then there must be some explanation of why the world is that way.

Why might someone think that this is true? Suppose we notice that although the sky is blue, it might not have been — the sky could have been red, or green, instead of blue. Doesn't it follow from this that there must be some explanation of **why** the sky is blue?

possible

necessary

contingent

Some have also thought that the PSR is a presupposition of modern science.

Science seems to proceed by discovering facts about the world and then asking what theories would best explain those facts. But doesn't that method basically just assume that the PSR is true?



Leibniz's
argument



the
PSR



objections
to the
PSR

The principle of sufficient reason

Every contingent fact has an
explanation.

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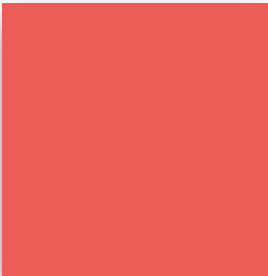
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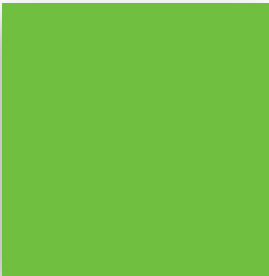
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cause exists, then God exists: the objection was that the first cause could

Last time we considered an objection to Aquinas' assumption that if a first

simply be some event, like the Big Bang, which is not a plausible candidate to

be Good.



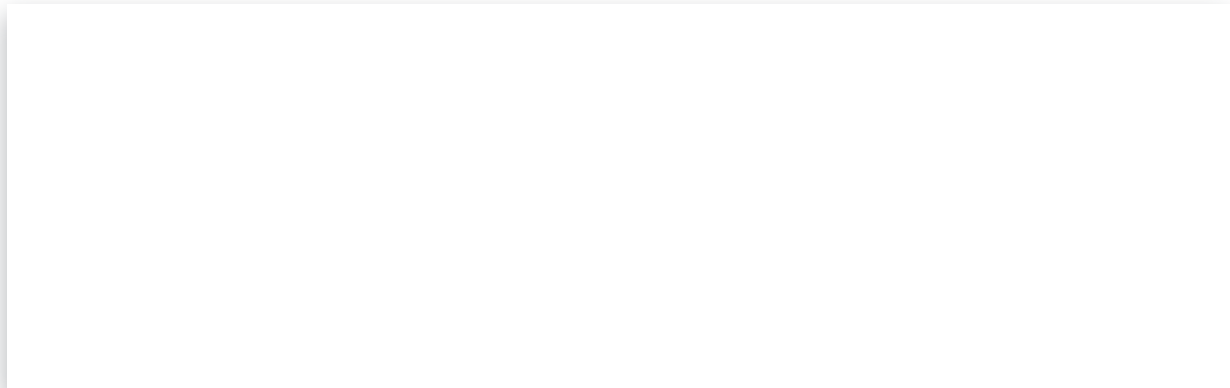
Leibniz's
argument



the
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Every intelligent fact has an

exp1a1nati0n.

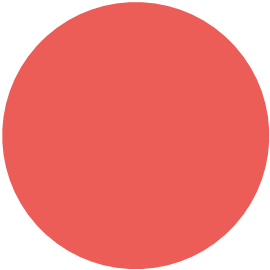
The principle of sufficient reason

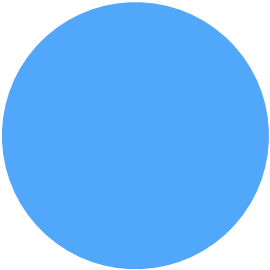
... we cannot find in any of the individual things, or even in the entire collection and series of things, a sufficient reason for why they exist.

Let us suppose that a book on the elements of geometry has always existed, one copy always made from another. It is obvious that although we can explain a present copy of the book from the previous book from which it was copied, this will never lead us to a complete explanation, no matter how many books back we go, since we can always wonder why there have been such books.

What is true of these books is also true of the different states of the world ... however far back we might go into previous states, we will never find in those states a complete explanation for why there is a world at all, and why it is the way it is.





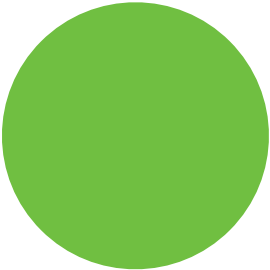








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